CARABAO CUP 2026/27 · THIRD ROUND

Chelsea v Leeds United

Stamford Bridge, London · September 9, 2026 (Wednesday) · Kickoff 2:00 PM Central / 20:00 UK

OFFICIAL STARTING XI

NO.	PLAYER / POSITION	FROM	AT CHELSEA	PREVIOUSLY	PLAYING STYLE	KEY STATS
– GK	**Mike Penders** GOALKEEPER	Belgium	Signed 2025; first-team squad from 2026 after a…	Genk; Strasbourg (loan)	Tall, quick off his line and comfortable with the ball at his feet.	2025–26, STRASBOURG (LOAN) 33 Ligue 1 apps, 50 apps all comps
6 CB	**Levi Colwill** LEFT CENTRE-BACK	England	Academy from 2012; first team since 2023 — 4th senior…	Chelsea academy; Huddersfield Town & Brighton (loans)	Left-footed, unflustered, progresses the ball through the left channel rather than sideways around it.	2025–26, CHELSEA — ACL RECOVERY 4 apps
5 CB	**Maxence Lacroix** CENTRE-BACK	France	July 2026, about £52m ($69m) from Crystal Palace	Crystal Palace; Wolfsburg; Sochaux	Reportedly the fastest centre-back in the Premier League by top speed.	2025–26, CRYSTAL PALACE 35 apps (all starts), 11 clean sheets
34 CB	**Josh Acheampong** CENTRE-BACK	England	Academy graduate; first-team regular from 2026	Chelsea academy	Composed young centre-back who reads danger early and is comfortable stepping into midfield with the ball.	—
– LWB	**Pep Chavarría** LEFT WING-BACK	Spain	July 2026 from Rayo Vallecano	Rayo Vallecano; Real Zaragoza	Attacking left wing-back with a reliable delivery and real stamina up and down the flank.	2025–26, RAYO VALLECANO 2 assists, 33 apps
– CM	**Valentín Barco** LEFT WING-BACK	Argentina	2026	Brighton; Sevilla and Strasbourg (loans); Boca Juniors	Left-footed wing-back with a fine delivery and a low centre of gravity.	2025–26, STRASBOURG 3 goals, 43 apps
– CM	**Reggie Watson** CENTRAL MIDFIELD	England	Academy; joined from Crystal Palace in his under-15 season	Chelsea academy; Crystal Palace academy	Composed central midfielder who keeps the ball moving under pressure.	FIRST SENIOR START, 9 SEPTEMBER 2026 16 years, 226 days
27 RWB	**Malo Gusto** RIGHT WING-BACK	France	Since Jan 2023 from Lyon	Olympique Lyonnais	Energetic, tenacious right-sided defender who overlaps hard and defends the touchline aggressively.	2025–26, CHELSEA 34 apps, 3 assists
11 AM	**Jamie Gittens** WINGER	England	Since July 2025, £48.5m plus add-ons from Borussia…	Borussia Dortmund; Manchester City academy	Left-footed touchline winger built on acceleration and one-v-one dribbling.	2025–26, CHELSEA 1 goal, 27 apps
41 AM	**Estêvão** WINGER	Brazil	Since July 2025, £29m plus add-ons from Palmeiras	Palmeiras	Explosive right-sided dribbler who shoots early and often from the left channel.	2025–26, CHELSEA 8 goals, 36 apps
– ST	**Danny Welbeck** CENTRE-FORWARD	England	2026	Brighton; Watford; Arsenal; Manchester United	Experienced forward who presses intelligently and holds the ball up.	2025–26, BRIGHTON 14 goals, 40 apps

Official starting XI, confirmed 1:10 PM CT. Last updated September 9, 2026, 1:55 PM CT. chelsea-fc-2026-27.netlify.app